

Elitism: normative ethics of local organisation in community-based natural resources management

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Abstract

Purpose – Local organisations have been established on participatory approach whose central purpose is to establish development activities bringing about positive change as four pillars of developments: to establish decentralised robust local organisation for sustainable forest management to enhance livelihood of rural people, to meet the forest products basic needs of local people, targeted interventions for poverty alleviation and social mobilisation initiatives and biodiversity conservation climate change mitigation and adaptation.

Design/methodology/approach – Local organisational elites designed/conceptualised the concept, where it can be operated organisationally and in local organisational context that provides new ways and methods to develop conceptual framework (Table I), which sheds light on involvement of poor and underprivileged members in decision-making process and distribution of benefit on equity basis.

Findings – The findings will lead to a positive change through the organisational elite model through both reorganising organisations and restructuring of power with change in the society and reduce the impact of rational choices, vested interests of elites (leaders of local organisation) and political factors, which are otherwise playing a game or tragedy of commons.

Research limitations/implications – Because of the limited resources and time, the authors are unable to verify it on the other development line agencies such as drinking water scheme, livestock, health and cooperative.

Practical implications – It considerably appears that the impacts are very sound to conclude from the review of above models of elites that provide a very clear understanding and useful conceiving lens to formulate how participation occurs in the executive committee of the community forestry user groups (CFUG) and community-based organisations based on three key elements. First are the caste and the caste structure of the community. Second is the wealth status of the individual, and third is power created both from wealth and caste. This should be determined from the local organisational elite model (Table I) about the nature of interactions on the executive of the CFUGs and other vehicles of local community-based development organisations.

Social implications – Local organisations will provide an opportunity in reality to both elites and non-elites to considerably change, make aware and create a realistic situation to determine the dialectical opportunity to develop relationship, interaction and configuration between elite and non-elite members both outside and inside of the local organisations.



Originality/value – It has not been found in literatures yet such sort of concept developed in development field particularly in the development activities performed by participation of local users. Hence, it is certainly original conceptual framework.

Keywords CBNRM, Elite model, Elite power, Local organisation, Organisational analysis, Power structure

Paper type Conceptual paper

Acronyms

CBNRM	= community-based natural resource management
CBO	= community based organisation
CFUGs	= community forestry user groups
CPR	= common pool resources
EC	= executive committee
FAO	= Food and Agriculture Organisation
NGO	= Non-governmental Organisation
UNICEF	= United Nation Children Fund
USA	= United States of America

1. Introduction

Organisations are social units that are designed to meet the needs and collective goals of the people linked within. In all organisations, the structure of management is of critical importance, because this determines the relationship between general members and the executive members who are appointed to make decisions and carry out tasks on their behalf. This, in turn, influences the actual decisions that are made and the outcomes that result from these decisions. Moreover, organisations are complex and inter-related systems where the executive members affect, and are affected by, external social factors and influencing situations (Yadav *et al.*, 2015b). Vecchio *et al.* (1988) argue that the study of organisations provides a strong framework to explore the nature of how social groups and societies as whole operate and make collective decisions. In the context of elitism, local organisations and society are often controlled by a small group of social elites who have the ability to act and exercise power for their own personal interests and gain (Farazmand, 1999). This study expands on traditional elite theory by formalising the concept of a *local organisational elite model* in the context of community-based natural resource management.

2. The local organisational elite model

It can be argued that a key outcome of organisational efforts, whether explicit or implicit, is that organisations facilitate the exercise of power and control by elites. In the context of community-based management of forest resources, this is so even when local organisations are established using a participatory approach whose central purpose is to establish positive change for poor and disadvantaged people and who are underpinned and interlinked with the involvement of poor households in decision-making (FAO, 1980; Kumar, 2002). Specific aims include some or all of the following:

- to establish a decentralised, robust local organisation to sustainably manage forests with the purpose of enhancing the livelihood of rural people;

- to meet the basic needs of local people with respect to forest products;
- to provide targeted interventions for poverty alleviation and social mobilisation initiatives; and
- to mitigate the impacts on biodiversity and climate change.

The understanding is that ordinary people do not benefit fully from forestry sector “trickle-down” or “top down” policy (Forest Acts, 1961, 1968, 1978) that allows forestry professionals to both create and enforce policies (Gronow and Shrestha, 1991). Additionally, Chambers (1983) asserts that the top-down approach encourages and empowers the “core people” (elite, rich, urban and industrial people) rather than the “peripheral people” (poor, powerless, rural and underprivileged people) in forestry management programmes. This approach has therefore been forcefully criticised by community developers and social advocates involved in formulating the participatory approach in the first place (Luitel and Bhattarai, 2006; MPFS, 1988).

In the example of Nepalese community forestry practice, elites dominate leadership positions within community forest user groups, and, so, the introduction of a participatory approach to management has merely shifted power from elites in central and regional governments to elites at the local level (Yadav *et al.*, 2015a). Furthermore, with the past decades of the forestry practices including forest management, protection, development and distribution of resources have been shifted from direct control and implementation of forest operation plans by the professional foresters to local communities. However, one form of management does not eclipse the other. The management of forests by professional foresters and the management of forests by community people, including elite leaders of community, are two faces of the same forestry coin. There is nothing inherent in a participatory community approach that generates better social outcomes or resource distributions when elite castes with wealth capture the Nepalese local organisations. In effect, at best, all that has happened is that the social impact of resources distribution has been obscured, because both expatriate and local foresters are able to overlook the distributional problems created by local elites. At worst, there has been a shift in decision-making away from experts with the knowledge and skills needed to draw poor and women into forest-based products obtained from community forestry. Therefore, the main objective of the new conceptualised organisational elite model is to empower poor and lower caste men and women by giving them control over decision-making processes.

A number of questions emerging from the community forestry management approach have been unanswered until now. First, who and what kind of community participants are involved in decision-making in rural development schemes? Second, what happens in a stratified society where the local power structure is controlled by elites or has an elite bias? Third, how can these organisations, including local organisations, be locally self-reliant, especially when the state has not formulated any reservation programme for poor and disadvantaged members under community forestry policy? Last, which organisations (non-governmental organisations [NGOs], community-based organisations [CBOs], etc.) persuade local organisations to resolve the problem of elite-biased decisions? Assuming that elites will not voluntarily abdicate their power, how can they be forced to in a society where all ordinary poor and underprivileged people are living with elites as clients and in patronage relationships?

Many organisations operate to support poverty alleviation programmes. However, most of the programmes such as drinking water schemes, irrigation, health and educations are directed, controlled and dominated by few local elite leaders whose decisions not only affect the entire organisations and ordinary members but also the notion of the participatory approach (Sampat, 2007). Sampat (2007) found empirically:

The local socio-political dynamic elite significantly affects any intended benefits that macro-policy initiatives envisage and if not made a crucial factor for consideration at the stage of policy and project formulation, it will only add to the distress of people who are already marginalized (p. 121).

In a field work carried out by Parker and Serramo (2000) in Malawi, Zambia, Zimbabwe; Bolivia, Honduras and Peru; and Paraguay and Cambodia, it was found that the elite ethnic caste and economic elites tend to operate organisations in ways such that the poor and lower caste (ordinary) people have constantly struggled to capture executive member positions of organisations. However, NGOs can play an intermediary role in the business development for the poor with a focus on the relationship between the NGO and local elites in Bangladesh (Makita, 2009). Moreover, Adhikari and Agrawal (2013) and Jamal (2008) empirically found that some NGOs were successful in compelling local elites to think about a broader social process and to take a more active role in the planning process for social developments that combine political, cultural and economic development. Larson (2002) also found that three key elements are needed to establish effective management of natural resources. These are capacity, incentive and a legally recognised conceptual framework that clarifies organisational structure and clearly establishes local decision-making authority.

In this paper, we conceptualise the local organisation elite model, particularly in the context of south Asia, where society is structured with a minority of caste and wealth elites and a majority of poor and disadvantaged groups. The hope of the new local organisational elite model is to create a system that will avoid the above challenges. The idea is to create a comprehensive structure to respond with several methods and styles, including coercion, reform, motivation, elite membership selection/election, creation of rules, regulations, practices and, most importantly, adaptation to meet the demand of rural poor and disadvantaged members.

Scholars of political science, economics, geography and anthropology have deployed a diverse set of theoretical lenses to define local organisations to examine specific villages and communities in the world. Despite the diversity in their approaches, they have agreed to a common definition of local organisation. Agrawal and Yadama (1997) defines:

the manner in which communities create, follow, and break formal and informal rules regarding the resources they control, the extent to which their autonomy of action is constrained, modulated, and facilitated by their interactions with the state, and the internal differentiation within communities along gender, caste, and class dimensions are critical to understanding how resources will be used (p. 436).

Hence, certain rules, basic norms and conventional values of society have the attributes of local organisation. For example, in the context of community forestry management, it becomes necessary to devise a definition of local organisation as:

[...] local Community Forestry User Groups (CFUGs) based membership organisation, which acts on behalf of community forestry users and is accountable for their membership and which

also involves their members on participatory approach for the selection of their leaders and decide on community forestry establishment, management, community forest products utilisation and benefits distribution.

The concept of the participatory approach emerged towards the end of the 1980s with the notion of *participatory development* or *participation in development* (Oakley, 1991, 1995). Oakley (1995) advocated participation regarding rural development as follows:

Participation includes people's involvement suggested in the key stages in the participation processes, decision-making, implementation programmes and sharing in the benefits for the development programmes, and the involvement in efforts to evaluate such programmes (p. 8).

The major development agencies, such as the Food and Agriculture Organisation, World Bank and United Nation Children's Fund have "latched on" to the concept of *participatory development* and have begun to see it as an, "antidote to the woes which befall their development programmes" (Oakley, 1995, p.7). Participation is perceived as a key indicator of a socially healthy, engaged and equal society (Perkins *et al.*, 2002).

CFUG is solely locally based organised entity of society that contributes to organise local people, sharing benefits among their members without aiming to generate profit for the operating members of the organisation for which it works. However, in practice, as the name proposes "local organisational elite model", organisations are elite-orientated or dominated with decision outcomes that favour more to the benefits of elites rather than other ordinary users. On legal base, the local organisations are self-reliant and can cover a wide range of formal and informal network with NGO, CBO and other line agencies. One of the aims of the participatory organisations is that their leader should be selected from a poor household that has a face-to-face relationship with other members. However, in practice, local organisations are usually elite-oriented and mostly work for their elite's benefit.

Thus, synthesised from the above organisation, in community forestry management, it deems that NGOs and social organisations empower local organisations that play a crucial role in inclusion of marginalised and underprivileged people in benefit-sharing and decision-making in cooperatives, community forestry, drinking water and irrigation and narrow down the influence of local elites. Migue and Wright (2015) and Ribot *et al.* (2008) found that engagement followed by civil society (NGO and CBO) approach in local democracy in which policy makers choose and cultivate elite-allied civil societies are more flexible and fair in decision-making in local development activities and provide opportunity to local poor to influence decisions in India, Indonesia, Russia, Brazil, Guatemala and Senegal.

3. Reasons to formulate new local organisational elite model

The key assumptions of the local organisation[1] are asserted by some scholars as follows. First, organisations are created by people, but few elites control and dominate the organisation (Higley and Pakulski, 2013; Highly, 2010; Farazmand, 1999; Wamsley and Zald, 1976). Social elites are more likely to be in leadership positions in the society. Adhikari and Di Falco (2009) assert that the elites and local powerful people who mostly embrace the key positions in the executive committee (EC) of CFUGs and, in many instances, capture the decision-making and implementation process of community

forestry. It is business as usual, where powerful people executive members of CFUGs decide and general users are disadvantaged in the community forest programme activities (Larson and Ribot, 2007; Dasgupta and Beard, 2007). Moreover, Shrestha and McManus (2007) and Kanel and Kandel (2004) also found that there is exclusion of the powerless group, especially poor, disadvantaged and lower castes, from decision-making process. There is a great monopolisation of power by local elite groups in community forestry. Hence, in the community forestry, elite-capture is seen as a serious problem.

Second, the role of the political and economic elites “determines the direction and processes of most organisations” (Farazmand, 1994). The rules, regulation and practice of community forest production distribution are formed by elites. Persha and Andersson (2014), Adhikari and Lovett (2006) and Ojha *et al.* (2009) found that elite rich members of community forests tend to be adequately represented in the meeting and decision-making process, and decisions and directions towards the management of community forests are largely dominated by socially and economically privileged section of the community.

Third, the underlying assumption is that the leaders lead the organisations on the basis of *pure rational interests*. Local organisation’s rules, regulations, directives and organisational operating systems of community organisations are developed by elite members of the user group in user group assembly. For example, Klooster (2000) found that elite members of the community forestry organisation in Mexico “dominate the communal organisations through intimidation, manipulating election, dodging oversight and discouraging participation in community assembly” (p.7). He asserts that violence, bribes, treats and manipulation of reciprocal obligation are the common internal tools in community politics to motivate and provide pressure to build rules and regulations of community forestry to achieve rational interests of elites. In contrast, Thoms (2007) found that local elites’ domination on decision-making on rational interests often results in strict rules that effectively lead to the well-protected forestry resources but, unfortunately, leads to the marginalisation poor users.

Fourth, the business-oriented enterprise, by nature and structure of the enterprise, contributes and enhances the existing political and economic system. The CFUG operating process and structure is also affected by existing political and economic system of the country, particularly for the selection of leaders and distribution of the benefits. It is a frequent assumption that rational individuals act in community organisation to receive greater individual benefit from the community forestry. Shrestha and McManus (2007) and Bushley (2014) assert his contrary view that individual benefits are not sole, whereas people are collectively working for the enhancement of forestry organisations. Individuals, particularly poor people, are effectively working with forestry organisations, because they have their socio-political circumstances that bind them to make continuity of their contribution.

Fifth, conflicts emerge among members of the organisations as a result of human nature and social classes when elites do not “abdicate their power and privileges” (Mills, 1956). For example, Adhikari and Lovett (2006) empirically found that about nine executive members in *Jyala Chiti* and five in *Shree Chap* community forestry user group of middle-hills of central Nepal retained their positions since the formation of CFUG,

because of “their economic interests in management of Common Pool Resource (CPR) and a desire to advance political power”(p. 439).

Sixth, the masses have right to withdraw legitimacy if they are not convinced by elite leaders; however, the environment created by elites is already conditioned and controlled by elite-operated organisation. Seventh, the elites “sit on interlocking board and reside in leadership positions”, where “masses and average individuals do not have access” (Higley and Moore, 1999, p. 337). Eighth, the elites have been rewarding the manager (technical experts) for their loyalty. Ninth, in the south Asian context, facilitating a diverse quality of stakeholder, including caste, rich, poor men and women dialogues and participation in natural resources management, requires many different skills and using appropriate methods. These required skills can be acquired through new concepts, methods and theoretical framework to participate as diverse stakeholders in community forest management and to access decision-making processes. The appropriate methods can only be allowed to poor men and women, including lower caste access on resources that makes easy combination efforts of science, policy and management. Finally, the leaders of the organisation are considered as the part of the organisation that serves the strategic interests of the apex elites, and value system and operational system of the organisation are developed behind the closed door, and “door at the top is usually closed” for general people (Farazmand, 1994, p. 39).

The assumption of the organisational elite model appears considerably similar but sets different perspectives on the concepts of elites and their attributes as hypothesised. Additionally, the most attributes of elites and concepts of organisational elite model provide a clear ground to formulate conceptual framework, because the elites present in the organisation lead the organisation on “pure rationality often claimed by other theorists” (Scott and Hart, 1989). Most of the decisions made by the elites are “limited and controlled by numerous gatekeepers whose primary function is to serve the elite’s interests rather than those of the ordinary people” (Farazmand, 1999, p. 337). Moreover, Robertson and Tang (1995) explain that with regards to rational choice perspectives, leaders (elites) focus on “enhancing the pursuit of the personal interest to rather than the collective interests”, for which the leaders need to be consistent in their action in an organisation. While reflecting with local organisational elite model, national-level elites who was elected as a Member of Parliament from one of the constituents of *Baglung* district (Nepal) had worked for seven years as a chairperson for the CFUG in his village, and he frequently influences election of executive members in CFUG. This is an imperative example of rational interest, and it predicted model particularly in the selection of leadership. It means that consistency is necessary to convince the other members so that personal interest of the leader will be attended by pursuing collective action. The process of getting benefits according to the elites’ interests is an internal part of organisational theory to the extent that “organisation tries to control environment to maintain their equilibrium” (Farazmand, 1999, p. 348).

Similarly, the local organisations are also legal organisations that involve their members from planning process to decision-making (Agrawal, 2001), where the selection of leadership position is also crucial. Dasgupta and Beard (2007) assert that selection of micro operational elite as a leader/manager is also a part of responsibility of the elites. Paudel (2015) found that CFUG organisation favoured rich elite households that derive more income than the medium and poor categories of the users obtained from community forestry. Armitage (2005) proclaimed some important exogenous and

endogenous variables and their relationship with resource management and power sharing to promote institutional and organisational diversity and identified that the role of power includes local elites biased against rural agrarian and/or traditional groups. Hence, the questions “who is in control of the EC of CFUGs?” and “is there any influence of elites to formulate distribution rules of community forest product?” correspond with the new local organisational elite model. [Jacobs \(2014\)](#) and [Farazmand \(1999\)](#) argue that micro operational elites serve the interests of the strategic elites and tend to act on the behalf of apex elites. [Knight \(1992\)](#) states that the organisational elite theory uses a dialectical approach as methods to be linked to organising processes, particularly the relationship between the leaders and the masses and elites and between elites at all level of organisation and society.

4. Background of the elite theory

Vilfredo Pareto and Gaetano Mosca, Italian political scientists and sociologists, are well known as pioneer spokesmen of elite theory ([Malesevic, 2010](#)). Both of them recognize that in history of modern society, there is a perpetual domination of disorganised large group by an organised small group. [Coleman \(1986\)](#) explains that the elite theory makes a possible connection of how social systems might be shaped by human will as:

The functioning of the society as well as the engine of social change could be grounded in the purposive actions of the individual, taken in the particular organisational and structure setting that shaped the incentive and thus the actions (p. 1310).

[Highly \(2010\)](#) claims that the origin of elite theory reflects with the most clear writing of social and political philosophers of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, such as Gaetano Mosca (1858-1941), Vilfredo Pareto (1848-1923), Robert Michels (1876-1936) and Max Weber (1864-1920). Mosca highlighted the ways in which petite minorities out-organise and outsmart large majorities that represent the political elites “usually has a certain material, intellectual, or even moral superiority” ([Highly, 2010](#), p. 161). Moreover, [Highly \(2010\)](#) asserts it as “political classes”. Pareto suggests that there is in fact an unrestricted social mobility in a society where elites would consist of the most talented and deserving individuals. However, [Highly \(2010\)](#) again claims that:

[...] in actual societies, elites are those most adept at using the two modes of political rule, force and persuasion, and who usually enjoy important advantages such as inherited wealth and family connections (p. 161).

In contrast, elites can help non-elites to define new areas and give new perspectives to involve in decision-making for public welfare in their surrounding environment ([Vromen and Collin, 2010](#); [Coleman, 2001](#)).

Although individual behaviour (cognition) is fairly well understood, group or cooperative behaviour (social/cultural) is an active area for finding solutions to benefit distribution problems of public goods ([Tomasello, 2014](#); [Ostrom, 1999, 2011](#); [Giddens, 1972](#)). The theories of society and human social action include social rules, processes, and how these rules and processes develop and organise people in society as individuals and as members of associations, groups and organisations’ functions are strongly related with the welfare of society ([Sztompka, 1994](#); [Ostrom et al., 1994](#)).

The elite theory can examine how power relationships are composed, the exclusion of social group, particularly low income and powerless groups from the powerful positions, and the degree to which powerful groups’ influences are exercised. The

scholars develop various definitions of elite for the formulation and development of the framework to analyse and interpret the elite approach to analyse the specific problems of the society. Some pertinent definitions of elite are discussed below.

Elite is taken from the Latin *eligere*, “to elect”. Central to the concept of elite theory is Mosca (1896) who introduced the term *classe dirigente* or ruling class to describe the power of ruling minority. Mosca (1896) explains elite as:

When a number of differing social types are mixed together in one state, a directing, if not strictly a ruling, class almost inevitably develops within the types that are in subjection. Sometimes this class is the first to be absorbed by the ruling type. The Gallic aristocracy, for instance, became rapidly romanised. It acquired the classical and juridical culture of the *Latins* within a few generations and was soon clamouring for Roman citizenship, which was readily granted (p. 106).

Mosca (1896, p. 107) further explains that similar concepts emerge “when there is any considerable difference between the customs, culture and habits of the ruling class and those of the governed classes”. Pareto (1916) tried to avoid confusion of the word “class” and use the word elite and later translated it into ruling elites. Pareto (1896, p. 25) defined it as “elites are those people representing the strongest, most energetic and most capable citizenry in concept” (p. 25). Pareto’s centrality to introduce the word elite to address the similar notion of Mosca who raises the question whether a narrowly defined ruling elite forms part of a broader and more all-encompassing non-ruling elites. Pareto further made his concept stronger with experiment and further defined in 1920 with a belief there are two classes of people in a society, namely, those who rule (the elite) and those who were ruled (the non-elite). He explained clearly the word elite with further dichotomy between those who ruled directly (ruling elite) and those who ruled indirectly (non-ruling elite). Mills (1956) argues the same sort of belief about the elites, particularly about the ruling elite in USA that US power structure is a fusion of economic, political and military dominants into a single power elite.

Mills (1956) asserts that powers have generally emerged from the shift of the structure of organisation with a relative position of political, economic and military order. Dahl (1958) asserts that “ruling elite is a minority of individuals whose preferences regularly prevail in cases of difference in preferences on key political issues” (p. 464). He further elaborates that “ruling elite is no doubt that small groups of people who make many key decisions” (p. 466). Bottomore (1964) explains that until recently, the terminology “elites” was applied to mainly powerful, influential group of business, professional, politician, military and public service leaders.

Putnam (1971) studied the role of the politician and leaders and explained the set of relevant political belief, values and habits of the political leaders of a political system; “elite political culture”. In the article titled “studying elite political culture the case of ideology”, Putnam (1971) defined political elites very loosely as “those who in any society rank towards the top of the (presumably closely intercorrelated) dimensions of the interest, involvement and influence in politics” (p. 651). Moreover, Giddens (1972) defines “elites” as those “individuals who occupy formally defined positions of authority at the head of a social organisation or organisation” (p. 348). When it explains the integration of elites, it assumes a number of dimensions such as social homogeneity, recruitment pattern, personal interaction, values consensus, group solidarity and organisational context as the main factors to bring them together (Gulbrandsen, 2012; Putnam, 1976).

According to Farazmand (1999), it is “the powerful position of a small group of individuals or groups who either shape or influences decisions” which affects the national outcomes. Thus, all the actors occupying key positions in the political, economic, military, governmental, cultural and administrative organisations are considered members of the elite, because they affect the national outcomes (p. 330). Highly (2010) defined with modification of the former definition as:

Elites may be defined as persons who, by virtue of their strategic locations in large or otherwise pivotal organisations and movements, are able to affect political outcomes regularly and substantially (p. 3).

When synthesized, the above definitions of Bjørnskov *et al.* (2014), Highly (2010), Farazmand (1999) Putnam (1971), Pareto (1896, 1920), Mills (1956) and Dahl (1958) elites are represented of a small group of people and individuals from the large society. The dimensions of their decisions are based on the interests and preferences and influences in decisions that affect the outcomes. It means a class of few people who rules and a more numerous class of people who are ruled and directed at and controlled by few.

4.1 Consensually integrated elite model

This model is devised for the top position holders of all major elite groups, including apex level of business, trade union, political government, mass media and academic groups (Farazmand, 1999). These groups are integrated with each other after a long process of fragmentation. Moreover, their integrations rest on international, national and local levels (Higley and Moore, 1981, 2001). In context of CFUG, it is a local-level social organisation[2] whose EC consists largely of village elites who make decision on behalf of user groups (Magraw, 2014; Fiorina and Abrams, 2008; Kumar, 2002). Frequent opportunity of interaction is present exclusively between local users and CFUG leaders. Both users and local leaders interact with each other when they have to decide business about the community forestry predominantly for the selections of leaders of CFUGs, management, utilisation, extraction and distribution of community forest products. In course of meetings, principally through the election and selection of leaders, some of new local elites emerge and connect with non-elites for their issues of community forest management. The local non-elites bring their disputes regarding distributions of community forest products demands to the elite leaders who provided them an opportunity to openly discuss and consensually make decisions. The decisions made by them bring them closer and establish mutual cooperation and trust. However, the monopolisation of local elites specifically in course of exercising power, non-elite and some elite and their coalition members who stand in opposition in course of election for leaders, suffer and struggle for power that brings them on the route of separation. Hence, this model is a suitable conceptualisation of the local organisation, specifically for the selection of leaders and distribution of community forest products.

4.2 Plural elite model

Plural elite model suggests that no single elite group controls the structure of the society. The interactions are less frequent, and network is based on different decision centres and are not consciously centralised in an inner circle (Farazmand, 1999). The formations of elites are based on social, economic, culture and symbolic attributes of society. Power is subsequently dispersed, and elites are multiple that rooted in a general pluralist notion of contemporary political system (Highly, 2010; Hazán, 2001). Etzioni-Halevy

(1989) and Porter (1955) claim that the plural elite model reflects with modern political system where elites are relatively autonomous in society who play a crucial role power exercise to political stability and democratic regime. Their connection for each other is only for the specific issues. As the elites are multiple, they represent the multiple views that are subsequently causes for their separation.

In context of CFUG, there are also multiple ethnic and wealth group constituted in society. Hence, they obviously have manifold thoughts, vision and aspiration regarding the decision-making for selection of leadership positions of EC and distribution of benefit from community forestry. The network is also not centralized to one specific group and explores all the hamlets of the user group. The meetings of the group are organised in different locations with the nature of case and agenda. Usually, they choose the public place such as school and community hall for big gatherings such as assembly meetings. Although the CFUG is constituted with a notion of non-political local organisation, political beliefs are obviously natural phenomena even in local level for every society in developing country like Nepal as affiliated with the election of EC members, including chair person. Hence, this model is also useful in this research context, because the CFUG is a local-level organisation and concentrated in village sub-village or hamlet level where local members less frequently interact for specific decisions (assembly meetings almost twice in a year) and organisations are controlled by small group of local elites.

4.3 Power elite model

This is not an inclusive model, yet a clear hierarchy of power and influences exists among elite group. The power elites are type of political system, kind of economic system, the bureaucratic structure of society and the level of development at the top most national level (Ahmad, 2010; Arslan, 2006). Moreover, at the apex of the hierarchical structure are business, political and, perhaps, military elites whose network is small and concentrated among the uppermost elites only for frequent interactions (Farazmand, 1999; Cammack, 1990). There is a considerable game of powers for the political leaders. However, CFUG governance at grass roots is a forum of participatory democracy and only constitutes for the management and utilisation of local natural resources, particularly community forest, and there is small scale of politics and exercise power in selection of EC members and decision-making process for distribution of benefit from community forest. Hence, this model could also reflect in some extent with research premises and problem.

4.4 Ruling class elite model

Elites are apex hierarchy and controlled by some of political ruling class. Scott (2004, p. 35) states that "the ruling elites are recruited from narrow and specific class and status backgrounds that they are most likely to develop a unity and cohesion of consciousness and action". The clear-cut positions of those top most elites who are present in most important decision-making processes are such that "their configuration must gravitate towards and around the centre elite" (Farazmand, 1999, p. 335). The interaction network is designed for the frequent interaction at uppermost level predominantly triumvirate (three powerful: economic, political and military groups) that is administrative in nature (Rock, 2010; Robinson and Harris, 2000; Domhoff, 1999). The power is dispersed only in upper level of political, economic and military elites, but relationship among these group

of elites are based for the operation of states, and the operations are fulcrums on which politics and policies turn (Duffy *et al.*, 2010; Scott, 2004). However, user group members are present in village-level meetings to set forest management objectives. Therefore, this model has no use in this research purposes.

4.5 Organisation elite model

Organisation operates under wealthy, elites and small group of powerful individual of society whose decision not only affects the internal structure and function of the organisation but also affects the outside environment and function of the organisation. Farazmand (1999) visualizes this organisational elite model for the general organisations from advanced industrial to lower social class group. This model is applied not only for ordinary people or mass of lower social class organisation but also operates in advanced industrial society and high bureaucratic organisations where positions interlock membership in political, economic and administrative elites of the nation (Stuart, 2007; Farazmand, 1999). Moreover, Hage and Dewar (1973) also explained that organisations determine their functions and performances through elite leader and his/her values. It means that organisation performs its behaviour on the basis of elite values and other structural variables of the organisation also related to the consigned interest of the elite leaders.

Therefore, let us first see what CFUG organisation is and how it is interlinked between forest resources and Nepalese stratified society. CFUG is a local-level social organisation operated by stratified traditional Nepalese society (ethnic elite, wealth elite, poor and underprivileged social class) on participatory democracy. It interacts with local people but not to advanced industrial society and high bureaucratic organisations. It deals a wide range of activities which link rural people with forests, trees and the products and benefits to be derived from community forest (Pokharel, 2002). The CFUG organisation controls and manages forest resource by the rural people who use them for domestic purposes and selling of surplus products for social development activities. The CFUG organisation comprises two different principles: social and natural resources. The natural resource can be considerably managed with clear understanding of silviculture and forest management principles, whereas social part of organisations will be dealt with high understanding of social configuration of stratified society and their integral relationship of day-to-day use of forest resources that correlate with the livelihood of rural people. The CFUG organisation comprises an EC where village elites dominate and make decisions on behalf of the group (Yadav *et al.*, 2015b; Kumar, 2002).

Hence, pertaining to these attributes, local organisations elsewhere in Nepal with some social stratified special features consent us to conceive towards a new *local organisational elite model*. This will provide lens to examine the specific problems that have been pertaining in Nepalese social structure organisation, particularly based in context of community forestry in Nepal. Moreover, it provides highly significant and clear understanding through the proposed local organisational elite model that is explained in the next section.

5. Local organisational elite model

Community elites have over past four decades of acquired central place within the participatory management of an organisation. However, as a participatory management is aiming to predict social outcomes, particularly in selection of leadership and

distribution of benefits to the local poor and underprivileged users of society where existing traditional social and organisational structure of society, have been established in the local organisations such as CFUGs. The focus on organisations within participatory approach has evolved over the past four decades in management of organisations, including Nepal (Ojha *et al.*, 2014; Gibson *et al.*, 2005). Despite a number of studies and importance of such resources distribution to poor and disadvantaged segment of the society, lack in model has produced some unconvincing results when hypotheses are subjected to empirical testing. Among the several factors, the local organisational elite model could be one of the models that can build up a considerable relationship between poverty and benefits distribution obtained from the local resources. For example, McDermott (2009) claim that community forestry is often better at delivering benefits to the poor and marginalised at the community and higher levels while developing better mechanism to benefit distributions.

The above theoretical reviews of the elite theory and its models, centrality of key organisation and their positions holders are emphasized as a necessary organisational mechanism through which elites act out and exercise power. It is this necessity which leads us to conceive a new elite model: a model of local organisational elite model. These local organisational elites designed/conceptualised the concept, where it can be operated organisationally and in local organisational context that provides new ways and methods to develop conceptual framework (Table I), which sheds light on involvement of poor and underprivileged members in decision-making process and distribution of benefit on equity basis. The following conceptual model (Table I) interacts with the executive members on the local organisation where local elites and non-elites, particularly poor and lower caste, where it is expected expect to find greater representation of low caste and the poor on the EC that contributes in the distribution of the of the local resources in their favour.

The major assumptions of the conceptual model of elites in CFUGs (Table I) are as follows. First, in a community where the EC is structured similar to the consensual elite model, one would expect to find only one caste and the rich dominating the EC, and this would be reflected in the distribution and rules of distribution that favoured the rich. Second, in a community where the EC is structured similar to the plural elite model, one would expect to find more than one caste and a mixture of the caste elites and the rich dominating the EC. This would be reflected in the distribution and rules of distribution that favoured the caste elites and rich. Third, in a community where the EC is structured similar to the organisational Elite Model A, or where the EC has a large proportion of poor, one would expect to find only one caste but the rich would not be dominating the EC, and this would be reflected in the distribution and rules of distribution that favoured the poor. Fourth, in a community where the EC is structured similar to the

Table I.
Type of interaction
with the executive in
a local organisation

		Caste structure		Creation of power From caste and wealth
		One caste	Many castes	
Wealth status	Rich	Consensually integrated elite model	Plural elite model	Power elite model
	Poor	Organisational elite Model A	Organisational elite Model B	Organisational elite Model C

organisational elite Model B, or where the EC has a greater proportion of poor or low caste, one would expect to find greater representation of low caste and the poor on the EC, and this would be reflected in the distribution and rules of distribution that favoured the low caste and the poor.

6. Significance/relevance and rationale of local organisational elite model

From the above study, it is seen that the explanatory power of the local organisational elite model is significant in a number of ways. First, dominant approach has been correlated with local organisation as a system that has objectives characteristics and the contingent effects. Underpinning this exertion is the idea that local organisation consists of key structure factors of the organisations: recognisable boundaries, organisational logics and inter-organisational structure within the local organisation (Kevin and Diana, 2014; Mutch *et al.*, 2006; Scott, 2004). The local organisational elite model[3] not only explains the organisational power structure, which comprise chairperson, vice chairperson, secretary and treasurer, who are key powerful members of the local organisation, but also explains the external and internal power structure and their relationship and interaction that more or less set the parameters for the organisational power and functions. The internal power structure and relationship of the elites with the poor, underprivileged and other disadvantaged caste groups of forest users involve the management and utilisation of forest resources and how it can change and maintain the relationship with those users. Moreover, the external power structure bounded with the government line agencies, such as district local development committee, NGO, CBO and bilateral projects, are involved in development activities. The concept of the boundaries reflects the function that has to be performed by the local organisation.

Second, the local organisational elite model is a prescriptive approach that provides attention on confirmation and reconfiguration in selection/election of members of EC from general members who make decisions that affects both the elite and non-elite members of the society. The perspective dimensions of governance structure when reflect local organisation's successful outcomes can be broadened in four categories: structure of the groups (ethnic castes and well-being category), organisational arrangement (include rules, regulations and practices to regulate the benefits), elite and non-elite cohesion and local resource attributes. These perspectives and dimensions of the local organisational elite model are considerably more significant and pay attention to establish organisations, formulate alternative modes of organisation, policy choice and influence decision-making to benefit distribution. Thus, it not only contributes to the normative theory of organisation but also considers mode of power structure both inside and outside of the local organisation. The underlying reason behind it is that local organisational elite is an integral part of the society (Bode, 2009; Malla *et al.*, 2005; Kumar, 2002). When the organisation works smoothly, they tended to overlook power, because general members focus on reality isomorphism, neglecting those coercive and normative elements (Covaleski *et al.*, 2013).

Third, the interactions and relationship of apex strata and the local elites help themselves to manipulate local organisation smoothly because of control and influence of power. Farazmand (1999) and Healey (2003) assert that a dialectal process is a methodical analysis of relations and interaction between elites and counter elites at all levels of the organisation, society and people.

Fourth, the suggestive model of local organisational uses rational interest of elites, which examines the interaction and relationship between principal (ordinary users) and agent (the executive members) in context of decision-making and benefit distribution from the local organisation. For example, [Delbridge and Edwards \(2007\)](#) outline that development in the new organisational theory has seen attempts to engage both leaders and ordinary people in a more holistic assessment of group-level dynamics and incorporate a greater sense of internal practice of formation of standard organisation.

Fifth, the proposed local organisational elite model would contend that developments on the organisational literature present an opening ground to debate about the ontological importance of the approach and reconsider organisational maintenance as an important area for theoretical developments. The idea underpinning level of analysis takes considerable significance in that the elites should be compassionate, honest, fair and flexible to the ordinary users and respect their demand during the implementation of local organisation. As a consequence, ordinary, poor and underprivileged members' positions and power will be increased. In contrast, the position of elites deteriorates when they present themselves as users aloof, self-serving and repressive. Additionally, the influence of the elites can be alleviated when the local organisational arrangement is enhanced and works in a user-friendly manner, particularly with the full participation of poor and underprivileged users:

Organisational and administrative elite become more of an instrument of domination and control for repression than an agent of positive change, service delivery and promotion of equity and fairness in society ([Farazmand, 1999](#), p. 349).

Sixth, this model will be used in all development sectors that work on participatory approach, including health, agriculture, irrigation, drinking water scheme, livestock, cooperative, etc. Seventh, the fairness and equitable sharing of benefits can only be achieved when it is an explicit objective of the benefit-sharing systems used by local governance structures that are based on inclusive approach ([Mosimane and Silva, 2015](#)). Eighth, local-level forest organisations to contribute to sustainable forest management have been negatively affected by lack of appropriate power and legitimacy ([Senganimalunje et al., 2015](#)). Ninth, [Haller et al. \(2015\)](#) have studied a four-case study of fisheries in Zambia; pasture and forestry in Mali; fisheries in Indonesia; and forestry in Bolivia and found that local powerful people influence local institution and it a new approach can be needed. Finally, it is expected that this local organisational elite model could examine the ways that will support to tie-up this relationship between local elites and ordinary users, specifically, poor segment of society.

6.1 Formation of local organisational elites

The local people who have access on private endowments such as large land holding size, greater off farm income, livestock holding unit, higher level of education, social prestige, wealth and elite caste are highly considered in the category of local elites. For example, the community forestry user group mainly is based on elites. The underpinning belief is that the local forest (range post) staff generally liaise with local or hamlet-level elites, and forest staff only rarely hold in-depth discussions to identify the needs, requirements and interests of the ordinary users in the

hamlet-level to making up the community forestry user group (Springate-Baginski *et al.*, 2003). Sekhar (2001) also explains that appropriate strategy would combine these different organisations with integrated approach that could be able to draw synergy between local elites and non-elites through an appropriate structured organisation. Even where wider discussions are held in the user assembly, they are organised by the help of local elites. Consequently, the local elites' views are presented in a form of free rider on non-elite users who often feel that their views have not been taken into account. Thus, local elites are greatly represented on the EC members of CFUG who hold decision-making power that make their confidence to create themselves as elites. An election system, without the clear rules stipulating the inclusion of unprivileged or minority people of the society, are easily created dominantly by powerful social group, particularly based on race, ethnicity and religion. For example, Yilmaz *et al.* (2010) and Dirks (2001) claim that the leaders who are elected by inclusion system of disadvantaged groups are now new elites or sometimes add power to local old elites who favour them to be more powerful who damage organisations and skewed decision-making as greater rent-seekers.

6.2 Connection of community forestry user group organisational elite

There are number of factors that endow local elites to connect with non-elites. The factors depend on the social structure and cultural inheritance. For example, the connections of industrial advance society such as USA, Britain, Canada, Australia and other Western countries are not that like of India and Nepal, where the connections are based on caste and religion. Further, conventions of Nepalese society are tied up regarding religion, culture, eating and drinking traditions. The orthodox high-caste Hindus are strictly vegetarian and do not drink alcohol, whereas other castes drink alcohol and eat pork and even beef. Similarly, the high caste belong to Brahmin, *Chhetari* and *Thakuri* strata of Hindu culture, whereas ethnic *Janjati* fall among the lower strata of Hinduism or either worship Buddha and other different religion. Therefore, it provides opportunity to the ethnic- and caste-based traditional society to connect with each other.

In context of community forestry, the connection between elites and non-elites is correlated with exercise of power, creation of rules and making decision, enforcement to connect each other for getting benefits obtained from community forest. For example, Lachapelle *et al.* (2004) state that caste composition also enforced them to maintain ritual purity, legitimatise the power of higher and reinforced a sense of fatalism in lower caste so that they are less likely to challenge unequal power distribution. Hayward (1998) states the social boundaries related to the norms, organisational actions and social identities regarding wealth, caste and religion enable them to connect them with people having similar principle and objectives and status.

6.3 Interaction of community forestry user group elites with others

There are several modes of interaction between local elites and non-elites at the recruitment stages, including election of EC members, decision-making for distribution of community forest products and selection of elite and non-elite users for training and allocation of opening period for collection community forest products. There are also some technical aspects of interaction between local elites and local foresters at the post formation stages, including technical advice for planning, managing local resources and

utilisation, particularly for the amount of timber, firewood and fodder to their vested interest. [Thoms \(2007\)](#) claims that:

[...] the majority of users see community forestry as the largesse of the elite, and take the word of elites as community forest law rather than learning, knowing or being aware of the formalized rules of use (p. 122).

7. Conclusions and implications of the local organisational elite model

It is our hope that the ideas and research presented here will help to stimulate the restructuring, reform and reconfiguration of local organisations currently dominated by elites. If so, our research has the potential to lead to positive change through the reorganisation of organisations and the restructuring of power relationships within society. It seems that there is a growing demand for the reorientation to more people-centred approaches to address many of the administrative and leadership issues involved in the organisations. This also means that the organisational elite model outlined in the conceptual framework can explain decision-making in CFUGs and form a way for poor and disadvantaged households to become part of the decision-making process. NGOs are likely to have natural interests in decentralisation of decision-making, particularly in developing leadership and managerial capacity to the organisations. As a consequence, poor and underprivileged members of organisation working together with powerful elites in a real participatory environment as local development programme in Nepal are expected.

The framework of the organisational elite model ([Table I](#)) raised important concerns regarding community-level decision-making for the management of community forestry. The three main elements of the model are:

- (1) the caste and the caste structure of the community;
- (2) the wealth status of the individual; and
- (3) the social power and influence created both from wealth and caste.

The main concerns are how to involve poor and low socioeconomic groups in decision-making. We argue that this should be determined from the local organisational elite model ([Table I](#)) about the nature of interactions on the executive of the CFUGs and other vehicles of local community-based development organisations.

Moreover, the findings of the study are relevant and applicable to explain and understand problems, particularly of public and community-based organisations which comprise members with heterogeneous social power. Similar problems exist in local government bodies and school management committee in developing countries. The case may apply to study problems of functioning organisations of trade union and business group associations, including roads, school improvements, health-care units and social security activities, which are also formed with members of heterogeneous socio-political or financial power. For example, Tharu, Madhesi including below-poverty-line ethnic group such as Mushar, Tharu, Chamar, Dhusad and so on in Terai (plain) region and Magurali (Magar, Gurung, Rai, Limbu) in Hill region of ethnic clusters and their associates who are residing since prehistoric periods. Therefore, local organisations should be inclusive where poor and disadvantaged groups including poor

women could be realized that this organisations will be work on equity and for the welfare of those groups, and wealthy elite caste can also enjoy proportionally, as they are the part of the stratified society on the local organisations.

Notes

1. There are various ways to define “organisations”. Bromley (1989) asserts that organisations are “set of ordered relationships among people which define their rights, exposures to the rights of others, privileges, and responsibilities whereas organisations exists because there is set of working rules which define them” (p. 43). North (1990) defines organisations as “organisations are the rules of the game in a society or, more formally, are the humanly devised constraints that shape human interaction” (p. 3). Bjorck (2004) and Scott (2004) define organisations as “organisations are social structures that have attained a high degree of resilience”. Agrawal and Gibson (1999, p. 637) defines organisations as “organisations can be seen as sets of formal and informal rules and norms that shape interactions of humans with others and nature” (p. 637). These definitions are interrelated with the role of community people in natural resource conservation. Definitions of organisations and organisations are more or less similar; hence, organisations and organisations are used interchangeably here.
2. Collectively, social organisations are association and device of social order, behaviours and cooperation of a set of individuals within a society. Moreover, people in a society believe in a system organised by attributes and pattern of relationship. The social organisation is different in Nepal based on stratification of Nepalese society. Social organisation of Nepal and social organisation of USA and England could be very different. Sociologists can only distinguish its structure of the family.
3. Local organisation refers to CFUG organisation.

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